Instagram data lab — instructions

the lab

ECOSM 2026 · Economics of social media and digital platforms · Giulia Caprini
Your own Instagram data, scanned and anonymised on your own computer, then explored and handed in. Nothing you drag into the lab is uploaded anywhere: the code runs inside your browser.

1 · Request your data from Instagram (do this a few days ahead)

1. Instagram app → your profile → the menu with three lines (top right) → **Accounts Center** → **Your information and permissions** → **Download your information** → **Download or transfer information**.

2. Choose your Instagram account → **All available information** → **Download to device**.

3. Settings: date range **All time**, format **JSON** (not HTML), media quality **Low** (or untick media). Confirm.

4. Meta e-mails you when the file is ready (minutes to a couple of days). Download the **.zip** to your computer and do not unzip it.

The zip is your raw data: it contains your messages, logins, IP addresses and more. Keep it to yourself; the lab makes a safe copy for the course.

2 · Open the lab

1. Open **https://gcapr.github.io/teaching_material_public_folder/instagram-data-lab/** in Chrome, Firefox, Edge or Safari (laptop or desktop; a tablet works, a phone does not). Nothing to install.

2. The first load takes about a minute: Python is being downloaded into your browser. Wait for the file browser on the left to appear.

3. Drag your export **.zip** from your computer into that file browser. It is stored in the browser's own storage on your machine only.

3 · Run the three notebooks

1. Double-click **01_scan_for_personal_data.ipynb** → menu *Run* → *Run All Cells*. It lists what personal data Meta holds about you (e-mail, phone, IPs, locations, contacts…) — masked on screen. Read it: this is the first lesson.

2. Open **02_anonymise.ipynb** → *Run All Cells*. It writes an anonymised copy: every person becomes *user_0001…* and you become *me*; message and caption text is reduced to word counts and hashtags; logins, devices, locations, contacts, payments are stripped; businesses and public accounts keep their names. Check the printed list of advertisers and public accounts, then read the report: it must say **HIGH findings: 0**.

3. The last cell of 02 writes **share_xxxxxx.zip** — the file you hand in (see section 4). Note your **share id**.

4. Open **03_explore.ipynb** → *Run All Cells*: thirteen chapters of charts about your own account — rhythm, conversations, network, what the feed showed you, ads, topics. This is the material for your memo.

4 · Hand in your anonymised data

In the file browser, right-click **share_xxxxxx.zip** → **Download**, then upload it at the link / QR code on the right. You will not see other students' files, and nobody sees your name in the data: the file name is a random id.

https://www.dropbox.com/request/win3z62dgdnmurvygjtd

What the file contains: the anonymised CSV tables, the anonymisation report and a manifest. What it does not contain: the pseudonym map, photos or videos, any text of your messages or captions, any e-mail, phone, IP, location, device or payment detail. The cell refuses to pack if the scanner still finds anything of the kind.

5 · Clean up

When you are done, right-click your export zip and the *anonymised* folder in the lab's file browser → **Delete**. They were only ever in your browser, but there is no reason to leave them there. Keep *anonymised/pseudonym_map.csv* private if you downloaded it: it is the only key to the pseudonyms.

If something goes wrong

The page shows old files / "No module named …"	The browser cached an earlier version of the lab. Delete the .py files and notebooks in the file browser, hard-reload (Cmd/Ctrl + Shift + R), then *Kernel* → *Restart*.
"Export not found"	The zip must sit in the lab's file browser (drag it in again). Its name must contain *instagram*; do not unzip it.
Notebook 02 is slow	A large export (thousands of messages) takes a few minutes in the browser. Leave the tab open and in front.
Report says HIGH findings > 0	Do not hand in. Check which file is named in the report and tell the instructor; the tool is updated within the day.
Export in HTML format	Request it again as JSON: the HTML pages cannot be anonymised.

Privacy, in one paragraph

The lab is a static web page: it has no server and receives nothing. All code (Python, running in your browser through Pyodide) is open and readable in the repository **github.com/GCapr/teaching_material_public_folder**, branch *ECOSM-2026*, folder *instagram-data-lab*. The only file that leaves your computer is the one you choose to upload in step 4, after the scanner has re-checked it. The pooled class data will be used for teaching only, with pseudonyms, and deleted at the end of the course.